

Trump will be major obstacle to an AI slowdown

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A rate hike runs the risk of a return to attacks on Fed independence

Trump will be major obstacle to an AI slowdown. Over the weekend, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei penned an article asserting that artificial intelligence firms must “pace the frontier” - a call for an intentional slowdown to build model safeguards that was later supported by OpenAI CEO Sam Altman and SpaceX Founder Elon Musk.

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Anthropic and other AI firms are unlikely to find political support for their proposed slowdown in the White House. President Trump and his administration view rapid AI development as a necessary strategic and economic hedge against a continually ascendant China. President Trump, to this point, has been keen on the US securing a first-mover advantage in AI, and his Truth Social post this morning affirms that he has no interest in supporting a slowdown in US AI development.

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Amodei’s plan banks on two key government concessions: an anti-trust waiver and a federal certification regime for frontier AI labs. However, White House AI Advisor David Sacks has declared that the administration does not intend to issue waivers for what they see as the illegal cartelization of the tech industry. Without alignment on waivers, AI firms run a real risk of incurring penalties under the Sherman Antitrust Act should they proceed with a coordinated slowdown.

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The Trump administration’s strategy is not without risks, however; it makes the administration politically vulnerable to future incidents similar to the recent OpenAI-Hugging Face controversy. Trump is unlikely to shift away from his AI bullishness until such a stance begins to incur real political costs, such as a future rogue AI incident with major economic consequences, or a major swing in the electorate against AI as such.

Kansas could only be the cherry on top of a Democratic Senate majority. A string of surprisingly close polls in the Senate race in the reliably Republican state of Kansas has generated some hope among Democrats that the state could be in play in November.

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Senator Roger Marshall (R-KS) hasn't led his Democratic opponent, Adam Hamilton, a Methodist pastor who used to be a Republican, by more than five points since January. That's a closer race than you'd expect given that Kansas went for Trump by 16 points in 2024: Even an eight-point national shift toward Democrats would suggest Marshall should lead by about eight points this year.

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Still, this race is very likely out of reach for Democrats, even with Hamilton's strong polling. This year's Kansas race looks like the latest in a continuing pattern in Plains states, wherein Republican candidates barely lead—or in fact trail—to independents or independent-minded Democrats, only to pull out comfortable victories in November. This occurred in Kansas in 2014 and in Nebraska in 2024.

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Democrats do have a clear path to the Senate, but it runs through states that leaned less Republican in 2024 and where Democrats have narrow polling leads—namely, Maine, Ohio, Texas, and Alaska. Kansas is likely winnable only in an extraordinarily strong wave year for Democrats.

A rate hike runs the risk of a return to attacks on Fed independence. If, as markets believe, Fed chair Kevin Warsh will deliver a rate hike at the central bank's meeting this week, President Trump likely won't be happy about it.

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Fed chair Kevin Warsh is probably not at risk of being on the receiving end of political attacks from the White House; unlike his predecessor Jerome Powell, he has a strong relationship with Trump for now and will likely receive wiggle room in his opening months as chair.

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It is the other members of the Fed board who will be more at risk. Trump in August blamed "a political board" for keeping interest rates high, and he is likely to do again if the board votes for a hike. That reaction could go beyond the usual broadsides on Truth Social and into more substantive areas, such as an acceleration of the reopened investigation into Fed governor Lisa Cook, or an attempt to remove Fed governor Michael Barr or San Francisco Fed President Mary Daly over their handling of the 2023 collapse of Silicon Valley Bank.

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While Warsh is politically insulated for now, that might not last forever; along with potential further interest-rate hikes down the road, attempts to defend under-fire Fed governors like Cook and Barr could lead to an escalation of tensions between Warsh and the White House over the coming months, leading to a situation not unlike that between Trump and Powell throughout 2025.

Quote of the Day

"I'll take on big pharma. I'll take on insurers, I'll take on hospital monopolies." – Michigan Republican Senate candidate Mike Rogers in a new ad; healthcare isn't a top issue for voters in the election, but rising healthcare costs are a key part of voters' affordability problems, forcing Rogers to lean into a message geared toward reducing healthcare costs. The Trump administration's efforts to bring down prescription-drug costs don't seem to have had much of an impact on the electorate, potentially due to rapidly rising premium costs.

On the Radar

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

1 October: Last day Congress is in session before midterms

3 November: National midterm elections

10 November: US-China tariff truce expires

18-19 November: APEC leaders meeting in China

11 December: Government funding runs out

14-15 December: G20 summit in Florida

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